

Spain: 2027 elections likely to produce right-wing government

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Right-wing parties are likely to win the 2027 elections. Eurasia Group sees a 75% probability of a right-wing government led by the main opposition PP||||||||||||

Spain

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Next year's elections likely to produce a right-wing government

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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The 2027 elections will likely take place in the first half of the year and yield a center-right government (a 75% probability), led by the conservative Popular Party (PP) with the far-right Vox as its junior partner.

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The ruling center-left alliance could still secure another term, but that outcome is unlikely given the right's solid lead, divisions on the left, and the government's corruption scandals and mixed record.

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A conservative government would take a more business-friendly stance, continue gradual fiscal consolidation, and tighten immigration policy, without seriously threatening EU relations or support for Ukraine.

Right-wing parties are likely to win the 2027 elections. Eurasia Group sees a 75% probability of a right-wing government led by the main opposition PP with Vox as junior partner, and a 25% probability that the ruling alliance of center-left, leftist, and regional parties retains a slim majority.

Combined, PP and Vox lead by more than 7 points in the polls, a margin Spain's electoral system would amplify into a majority of about 25 seats in the 350-seat parliament. Recent election results suggest the polls tend to overstate the right's strength, but the two parties would still be within reach of a comfortable majority.

Corruption scandals and a weak government record weigh on the left's prospects. The lack of an effective parliamentary majority has crippled Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez's legislative agenda and blocked passage of the budget since 2022. Sanchez has occasionally brokered agreements in parliament, most notably on spending measures to cushion energy price increases this year, but that task will get harder as the elections draw closer. The government will present a 2027 budget bill before year-end, but it has no realistic chance of passing.

Support for the ruling Socialist Party (PSOE) has weakened amid a growing number of serious corruption allegations involving Sanchez's senior associates and family members. Ongoing judicial proceedings will, at best, keep the issue in the headlines for months; at worst, they will uncover more incriminating evidence. Mismanagement of the Ceuta migration crisis in August will further dent its prospects. Having failed to prevent a mass breach of the Spanish enclave's land border with Morocco, ministers have spent the last month trading accusations while the issue festered.

Divisions on the left, low approval ratings, and incumbency headwinds create additional obstacles. Spain's electoral system tends to reward larger parties. That dynamic puts the center-left at a significant disadvantage as it is split across seven parties, many of which poll at 2% or less.

Sanchez's approval ratings have fallen into the low 30s, a level at which incumbents' reelection prospects typically weaken sharply. Polling on key issues also favors the opposition. The economy, the cost of living, and housing dominate voters' concerns, even as Iran-related energy prices push inflation higher again. Spain's economy has performed well, but real per-capita income gains have been more modest, and PSOE voters are on average more exposed to price pressures, though spending measures to address higher prices, minimum wage increases, and pension indexation are important offsets.

Still, a PSOE victory should not be ruled out. Sanchez turned around difficult elections late in the campaign in both 2019 and 2023. A third such recovery is harder given the headwinds outlined above, but not impossible. It would require two conditions, neither of which is likely. First, PSOE's allies would need to consolidate at least partly into a single political vehicle; despite some pressure in that direction, narrow party interests will likely prevent it.

Second, PSOE would need to recover some of its lost ground. Sanchez has repeatedly leveraged the prospect of Vox in government to mobilize left-leaning voters. With Vox already approaching 20%, a further surge at PP's expense, driven for example by more immigration-related events or the imminent return of an exiled Catalan separatist leader, would make that strategy more plausible.

The elections will likely be held in the first half of 2027. The vote must be held by 22 August. Although snap elections before the end of 2026 cannot be ruled out, the most likely window is now February to April 2027, which would give the government enough time to present a 2027 budget bill. Regional leaders in the ruling party will likely oppose holding the vote alongside May's important regional and local elections, fearing Sanchez's poor showing would drag down PSOE at the local level. A summer vote is less likely, given the government's concerns over further erosion in support.

A PP-Vox government would likely take a mainstream center-right posture. It would be closer to that of Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni than to any radical break with EU commitments. On economics, it would continue gradual fiscal consolidation, combining spending cuts with targeted tax reductions. Foreign and security policy would stay aligned with the EU mainstream: pro-Ukraine, supportive of higher defense spending, and closer to the EU's tougher approach toward China. The government would likely tighten Spain's lax immigration policies. It would stop short of mass deportations, but the shift would still weigh over time on labor supply, a major driver of recent GDP growth. Spain would likely remain a leader in decarbonization, but Madrid would probably join other center-right governments in seeking to weaken EU climate policies that industry and consumers view as burdensome. It would also likely delay the nuclear phaseout.

Federico Santi
Senior Analyst, Europe
+44 20 7375 6930
santi.ne@eurasiagroup.net
EG Europe
europe@eurasiagroup.net

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